

Getting Home: With Communication, Love, and Practice

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I am in the process of getting home. I can't say that I am definitively there, but with careful attention to communication, love, and practice, I know that I am close. Maintaining a queer orientation toward home, my sovereignty is in the work of never settling, in the constant recognition of how I so desperately long for my desires, and in the continuous practice of going somewhere better. I also know that I am not alone in this journey.

Because the long and violent histories of imperialism, colonialism, and nationalism are ingrained in *The House that Race Built*, for Toni Morrison, the opening essayist in Wahneema Lubiano's edited collection on Black American politics of the new millennium, home is "a-world-in-which-race-does-*not*-matter."¹ Not to be confused with the renowned African-American novelist's 2012 novel of the same title,² Morrison's beginning essay entitled "Home" recalls her experience in writing the 1992 novel, *Jazz*,³ by indicting the unresolved problem of language. It is both liberating and imprisoning.⁴ As a metaphor, home expresses Morrison's desire for a transformation of the house of racism. This distinction between house and home evokes the writings of legendary lesbian feminist scholar and poet, Audre Lorde, who wrote "Uses of the Erotic: The Erotic as Power" as well as "The Master's Tools Will Never Dismantle the Master's House."⁵ Equally important to Morrison's opening chapter, but without mention, the power of

the erotic inspires her metaphor of home, an expansion of Lorde's analogy of the "master's house."⁶

Following in the vein of Lorde, queer theorists have continued to imagine, redefine, and trouble what home means and how to get there. Anthropologist Chou Wah-Shan refers to home, or the Chinese term *jia* as a "mental space" that encompasses not only the house and family, but the "roots to which a person belongs."⁷ Wah-Shan finds that recognition for many *Tongzhi*, or LGBTQ, subjects occur through mundane practices such as eating dinner with family. If sharing with others through ritual and tradition is a means of recognition across difference, then "coming home" is an alternative to the white, Western dominant narrative of performatively coming out. As Benny LeMaster notes, this takes time.⁸ Similar to "coming home," *getting home* is a quotidian practice of self-recognition enveloped in a world of relations. However, self-proclaimed feminist killjoy, Sarah Ahmed maintains that homes can create a false sense of intimacy. Enraptured by the lure of home security, we settle such that the "body and the rooms in which it gathers . . . cease to be distinct."⁹ In this way, *getting home* insists that a queer subject never fully arrives, but instead always exists in a perpetual process.

Animating Morrison's metaphor of home with Lorde's theory of the erotic, this article develops the project of *getting home* by paying attention to language and love while queering the practice of settling within houses constructed out of identity politics. For example, according to Lorde, oppression is the source of constant and exploitative misrecognition whereas the erotic is an "unexpressed or unrecognized" potential.¹⁰ Communication is crucial to *getting home* because reconciliatory recognition cannot happen without expression. Furthermore, that which is articulated is always part of a conversation. Critical love sustains dialogues across difference. But neither mastering communication nor embodying love will set us free. Such strategies alone are weathered tools. Rather, freedom is also in the endless practice of *getting home*. How do you arrive somewhere that is boundless?

In the master's house, as the creative nonfiction writer Rasheena Fountain sharply puts it, "I am not home." Rather, home is in "the birds, the sea, and forests."¹¹ Homes may have neighbors, but houses come with new department stores, corporate skyrisers, and correctional facilities. Structures of racial capitalism impede our ability to soak up the sun, see the stars, and slip out to sea. They prevent us from seeing one another, even when large flashing billboards hang overhead. Lorde calls for an embrace of the erotic as a space between "the beginnings of our sense of self and the chaos of our strongest feelings."¹² *Getting home* then, is to draw from an erotic well; its "replenishing and provocative force" allows us to continuously pursue the genuine change that is necessary

for building a better world.¹³ It means constantly contending with our unmet material needs for safety and allyship while navigating houses and the identity politics they come to represent. *Getting home* necessitates imagining a place “‘already made for me, both snug and wide open, with a doorway never needing to be closed,’” and possessing the incessant drive to get there.¹⁴ *Getting home* is the practice of being in a world of rooms and at the same time within a womb of worlds. Writing about self-love is a queer journey with no end in sight. For how can I truly love myself when, in this world, I am always somehow complicit in the suffering of others? *Getting home* is the beginning to the end of this world.

Through the Purchase of Communication

Getting home is a procurement, an orientation, and an understanding. To get home, you first have to buy into the idea that it exceeds the material, stretching beyond the notion of four walls and a roof. An otherworldly space formed by who you are and where you are from, home exists in a place and time of what Sylvia Wynter deems the “demonic grounds.”¹⁵ Home is a space prior to language and therefore is also always a “race specific yet nonracist” harbinger of abnegation.¹⁶ Hortense Spillers, who wrote around the same time as Morrison, Lorde, and Wynter, troubles the “twinned” motivations of the African-American freedom project by examining the violence of gendered familial relations.¹⁷ Misnaming cuts such that it severs the possibility for kinship. Mistaking a house for a home can have the same effect. As Lorde has demonstrated, the movement for freedom inextricably tethers recognition with the creation of new spellings of our names.¹⁸ Self-definition dismantles patriarchy, a process of property acquisition, even as it remains in syntaxial relation to what Spillers calls the American Grammar Book.¹⁹ Home is within the feminine and the erotic, but it is not solely reserved for women.

As a continuously evolving story of me, my home is an “inwardness of the outside,” a fleshy-feeling lexical poesis.²⁰ It is a storehouse of erotic power, my respite, my drive, and a place of constant return. It is like the “longed-for bed” that Lorde conjures, each day arising from it and returning to it for rest.²¹ As a synecdoche, Lorde’s bed is a small part within a house that represents the wholeness of home. On the flip side, Morrison’s home as a metonym is loosely associated with the deconstruction of the material house of race. Overall, Lorde uses the metaphor of home to expand the potential of the erotic beyond the libidinal,²² whereas Morrison uses the same metaphor to craft a sense of security in spite of the master’s house.²³ Procuring “home,” by rhetorical means of synecdoche and metonymy, I make purchase for a different world: one in which my

home is built using the power of the erotic to create a sense of “safety without walls.”²⁴

By a Queer (Dis)Orientation to Love

Although a collection of houses makes a neighborhood, nearby homes do not always make great neighbors. As Ahmed explains, pressure points of difference accumulate as lines that divide and create, forming imagined spaces like shared fences.²⁵ We come to expect and even demand that our neighbors, as reflections of ourselves, construct their homes along particular boundary lines to exclude certain bodies, else they become menacing threats to our own sense of security. *Getting home*, understood solely through communication, situates some subjects and objects in reach, and leaves numerous others unavailable. Thus, a queer politics of (dis)orientation hails us to renovate the home envisioned by Black feminist writers of the 1980s. Revisionist politics suggest that further transformation is always necessary. Rather than stopping the critique at the paradox of politicized identities as partitioning structures, we must imagine beyond limitations.²⁶ Yes, even the umbrella term “queer” runs the constant risk of becoming a gated community dominated by a pesky HOA. Still, for Juana María Rodríguez, queer sociality is queer fantasy,²⁷ and in Ahmed’s words, homes are “*overflowing and flowing over*.”²⁸ Here is where the metaphor of a house fails altogether, for fences and walls are not natural cordons nor predilects for safety. Alliances are illusory and still, they remain necessary.

Allyship based solely on identity politics, even queer identity, assumes that our affinities are fixed and natural. In actuality, these boundaries are like semi-permeable chain-link fences. If we aren’t careful, such fences become “a way of life, or even an expression of who we are.”²⁹ I often find myself inquiring if spaces are exclusively QTPOC as though queer, trans, and people of color communities are undoubtedly safer. Such acronyms are not always sufficiently inclusive. I tend to bristle when I encounter someone from the “gayborhood” who clearly has a different approach to queerness than me. I feel fooled when I think we live on the same block only to find out we live worlds apart.

How can I be concerned with queer affinity when I have yet to fully arrive in the truth of my own queer position? Ahmed complicates *getting home* noting, “our intimacy with rooms, even dark ones, can allow us to navigate our way.”³⁰ My inability to fully grapple with my identity is disorienting, and yet disorientation is what necessitates my desire to *get home*. When I can articulate how I fail as an ally, I help myself and others realize this world is not yet the one we long for. I am failing all the time.

In the erotic sense, home has the power to transform any potential threat in the complexity of navigating difference using “the passions of love, in its deepest meanings.”³¹ *Getting home* is a form of daily relational understanding. Perhaps this is best captured by the “erotic truth” that Alison Bechdel describes at the end of *Fun Home: A Family Tragicomic*. In depicting the unsettled dynamic between her and her deceased father alongside the dysfunctionality of their family, she articulates the necessarily intimate yet conflicting politics of queer familial love.³² However, *getting home* is more than the acquisition of self-recognition or familial acceptance, and it is more than queer (dis)orientations. Whether one is in or out of the closet, the master’s house continues to jeopardize our ability to fully connect with one another.

With an Understanding of Desire as Practice

Even though familial units are systems of power, when I tune into the erotic, I can better understand my desire for family. *Getting home* means I comprehend or “get” my queer desires for communication and love. In an autoethnographic dialogue about coalitional politics, Shinsuke Eguchi and Hannah Long reimagine the potential of a queer family stating that “learning to embody critical (queer) love” can perhaps allow for transcendence of the “hegemonic, heteronormative, and homonormative paradigms of relating.”³³ Grasping the complexity and contradictions of my desires produces a state of femme flux rooted in critical love and enveloped in the fleeting practice of becoming through articulation.³⁴

I am *getting home* when I rest in *Savasana* for a few minutes noticing how I benefit from and am hurt by cultural appropriation as a Black yoga teacher; when I stand at the sink, letting water run as I do dishes by hand, my thoughts lost in a Zapatista-inspired print I acquired while studying abroad in Oaxaca; when I allow myself to collapse into a fit after staying up until dawn working on a school project, my fingers dipped in glitter armor provided by Vietnamese women at the nail salon;³⁵ when I take a walk around the block with my dog, our bodies moving with the beat of misogynistic music blaring from my headphones; when I pine for hetero-type relationships with seemingly uninterested men despite my attraction to women and knowing that I deserve better. I am *getting home* when I revisit the basement of my memories and the attic of my dreams; when I listen to the five-year-old me, the one who was so furious she vowed, with a furrowed brow, to seal her lips because no one would understand; when I allow my desires to swell to their fullest capacity, all the “should nots” and “could nots” that I definitely do want but dare not, brimming at my throat; when I mouth “I love you” in the mirror while playing in my makeup bag, even

if after a slight hesitation and then begrudgingly with an air of fake it 'til you make it.

A threat to your neighbor's house quickly becomes a threat to your own. Yet you can only help put out a fire in another's house if you are home yourself to see the smoke. With allyship, there is room for error just as there is room for recognition.³⁶ *Getting home* is a process of "self-connection," it is a responsibility to not "settle for the convenient, the shoddy, the conventionally expected, nor the merely safe."³⁷ It is the constant attempt to love myself in the face of external and internalized hate. To love myself through loving others is a critical and circadian practice. It is, as Andrew Spieldenner and Eguchi write, a simultaneously dissonant and synergetic process of negotiating across difference and rectifying unearned privilege.³⁸ *Getting home* deconstructs the house in order to build a better world for ourselves and others.³⁹ In a world of disaggregation, our neighbors are our allies. All alliances, whether failed or successful, are "homing devices" that help us remember how to get back to our desired future.⁴⁰

In the magical real of Morrison's novels, in the intersectional politics of Lorde's feminist musings from the 1980s, and even during the COVID-19 pandemic, *getting home* is a matter of life and death.⁴¹ Suspended in the continual and triptych process of practicing how to speak my truth and love myself, I am on a poorly lit path and each porch light helps.⁴² Thus, how queer it is that in this world we might get to know our neighbor by first getting ourselves home, only to later realize that this neighbor is not necessarily interested in talking queer politics over a potluck dinner when you've invited them into your house.

Notes

- 1 Toni Morrison, "Home," in *The House that Race Built*, ed. Wahneema Lubiano (New York: Vintage Books, 1998), 3.
- 2 Toni Morrison, *Home* (New York: Vintage International, 2012).
- 3 Toni Morrison, *Jazz* (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1992).
- 4 Morrison, "Home," 5.
- 5 Audre Lorde, *Sister Outsider: Essays & Speeches by Audre Lorde* (Berkeley, CA: Crossing Press, 2007).
- 6 Audre Lorde, "The Master's Tools Will Never Dismantle the Master's House," in *Sister Outsider: Essays and Speeches by Audre Lorde* (Berkeley, CA: Crossing Press, 2007), 110–113.
- 7 Chou Wah-Shan, "Homosexuality and the Cultural Politics of *Tongzhi* in Chinese Societies," *Journal of Homosexuality* 40, nos. 3–4 (2001), 35.
- 8 Benny LeMaster, "Telling Multiracial Tales: An Autoethnography of Coming Out Home," *Qualitative Inquiry* 20, no. 1 (2014): 58.

- 9 Sarah Ahmed, *Queer Phenomenology: Orientations, Objects, Others* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2006), 11.
- 10 Audre Lorde, "Uses of the Erotic: The Erotic as Power," in *Sister Outsider: Essays and Speeches by Audre Lorde* (Berkeley, CA: Crossing Press, 2007), 53–59.
- 11 Rasheena Fountain, "A Difficult Trek with My Daughter," *Hobart*, February 10, 2020, https://www.hobartpulp.com/web_features/a-difficult-trek-with-my-daughter.
- 12 Lorde, "Uses of the Erotic," 54.
- 13 Lorde, "Uses of the Erotic," 54, 59.
- 14 Morrison, "Home," 12. .
- 15 Sylvia Wynter, "Beyond Miranda's Meanings: Un/silencing the 'Demonic Ground' of Caliban's 'Woman,'" in *The Black Feminist Reader*, ed. Joy James and T. Denean Sharpley-Whiting (Malden, MA: Blackwell, 2000), 107–27.
- 16 Morrison, "Home," 5.
- 17 Hortense Spillers, "Mama's Baby, Papa's Maybe: An American Grammar Book," *Diacritics* 17, no. 2 (1987): 79.
- 18 Spillers, "Mama's Baby," 65.
- 19 Audre Lord, *Nami: A New Spelling of My Name* (Berkeley, CA: Crossing Press, 1982).
- 20 Morrison, "Home," 12.
- 21 Lorde, "Uses of the Erotic," 55.
- 22 Lorde, "Uses of the Erotic," 54.
- 23 Morrison, "Home," 3.
- 24 Morrison, "Home," 12.
- 25 Ahmed, *Queer Phenomenology*, 14–17.
- 26 Lee Edelman, "Queer Theory: Unstating Desire," *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian & Gay Studies* 2 (1995): 343.
- 27 Juana María Rodríguez, "Queer Sociality and Other Sexual Fantasies," *GLQ: A Journal of Lesbian and Gay Studies* 17, nos. 2–3 (2011): 336.
- 28 Ahmed, *Queer Phenomenology*, 11.
- 29 Ahmed, *Queer Phenomenology*, 19.
- 30 Ahmed, *Queer Phenomenology*, 7.
- 31 Lorde, "The Uses of the Erotic," 56.
- 32 Alison Bechdel, *Fun Home: A Family Tragicomic* (New York: First Mariner Books, 2007), 36.
- 33 Shinsuke Eguchi and Hannah R Long, "Queer Relationality as Family: Yas Fats! Yas Femmes! Yas Asians!," *Journal of Homosexuality* 66, no. 11 (2018): 1–18.
- 34 Sydney Fonteyn Lewis, "'Everything I know about being femme I learned from Sula' or toward a Black Femme-inist Criticism," *Trans-Scripts* 2 (2012): 100–25.
- 35 Lewis, "'Everything I know about being femme,'" 100.
- 36 Rodríguez, "Queer Sociality and Other Sexual Fantasies," 332; Andrew R. Spieldenner and Shinsuke Eguchi, "Different Sameness: Queer Autoethnography and Coalitional Politics," *Cultural Studies ↔ Critical Methodologies* 20, no. 2 (2020): 8.
- 37 Lorde, "Uses of the Erotic," 57.

38 Spieldenner and Eguchi, “Different Sameness,” 2–6.

39 Lorde, “Uses of the Erotic,” 58; Lorde, “The Master’s Tools,” 111; Morrison, “Home,” 12.

40 Ahmed, *Queer Phenomenology*, 9.

41 “Joint Statement by NAACP and The Links, Incorporated on Collective Outrage Regarding the Police Murder of George Floyd and Other Victims of Law Enforcement,” *NAACP Press Release*, June 2, 2020, <https://www.naacp.org/latest/joint-statement-naacp-links-incorporated-collective-outrage-regarding-police-murder-george-floyd-victims-law-enforcement/>. RIP Ahmaud Arbery, Breonna Taylor, George Floyd, and countless others.

42 Morrison, “Home,” 6–7.

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